Reactions to the Gillette "We Believe" Advertisement on r/MensLib and r/MensRights

Findings

16 October 2026

Measures, sample construction, inference and validation are documented separately in *Methodology, Statistics and Replication Materials*. This document reports what was found. Throughout, *tone* is the affective valence of a comment's text and *stance* is the position it takes on the advertisement; the two come apart, and most of what follows depends on the distinction.

1 The communities took opposite positions on the ad

Among comments that take a position, **86.4 % of r/MensRights is critical of the advertisement against 12.9 % of r/MensLib, which is 71.8 % supportive.** The gap in critical share is −73.7 points (95 % CI −78.3 to −69.6).

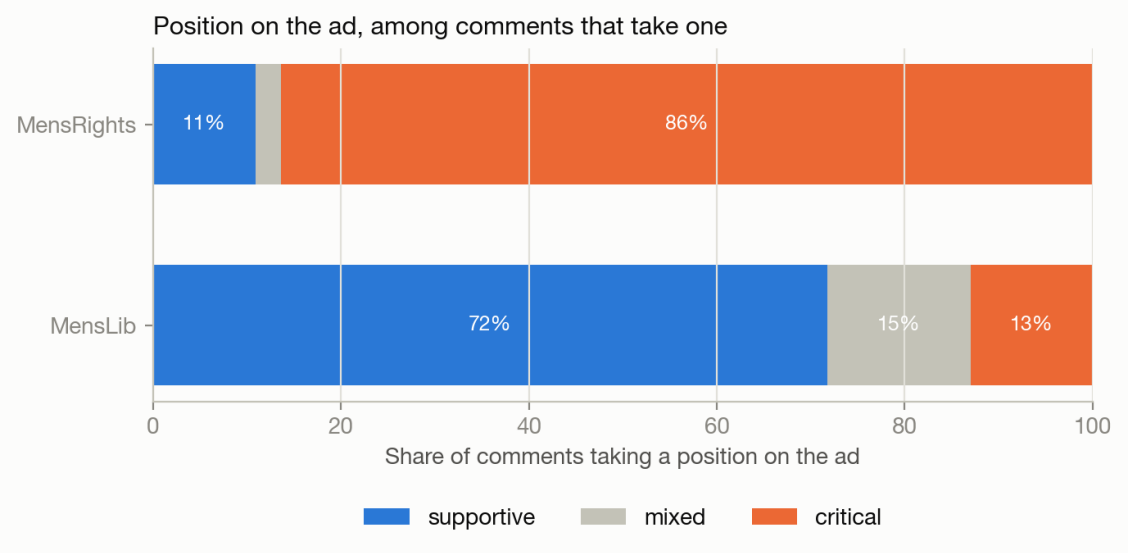


Figure 1: Position on the advertisement, among the 6,552 comments that take one

Both communities engage at a similar rate: 38.2 % of r/MensLib comments and 42.0 % of r/MensRights comments take a position at all. The difference lies in what they said, not in how much they cared.

The result holds from −70 to −75 points across every specification tried, and it survives the moderation problem described in §4: assuming every removed r/MensLib comment was critical and every removed r/MensRights comment was supportive, the gap still runs from −50 to −77 points. Adjusting for comment length, reply depth and period, the odds that a positioned comment is critical are **34.9 times higher** in r/MensRights (95 % CI 24.4 to 49.9).

2 Resentment, identity threat, zero-sum thinking and hostility

All four constructs are higher in r/MensRights, with zero-sum thinking showing the largest relative gap and resentment the largest absolute one.

Zero-sum thinking is roughly seven times more present in r/MensRights and close to absent in r/MensLib, where only 0.5 % of comments rate it clearly present. Resentment is the largest in

Table 1: Construct ratings, 0–3, where 0 is absent and 3 strong and central

	Resentment	Identity threat	Zero-sum	Hostility
r/MensLib, mean	0.333	0.340	0.057	0.122
r/MensRights, mean	0.908	0.747	0.451	0.416
Clearly present (≥ 2), r/MensLib	5.2 %	10.4 %	0.5 %	1.5 %
Clearly present (≥ 2), r/MensRights	29.8 %	23.6 %	11.2 %	10.1 %
Difference [95 % CI]	−0.575	−0.407	−0.394	−0.294
	[−0.66, −0.48]	[−0.57, −0.24]	[−0.44, −0.34]	[−0.33, −0.27]
Cliff's δ	−0.292	−0.192	−0.276	−0.178

absolute terms: nearly a third of r/MensRights comments carry a clear sense that men are being wronged.

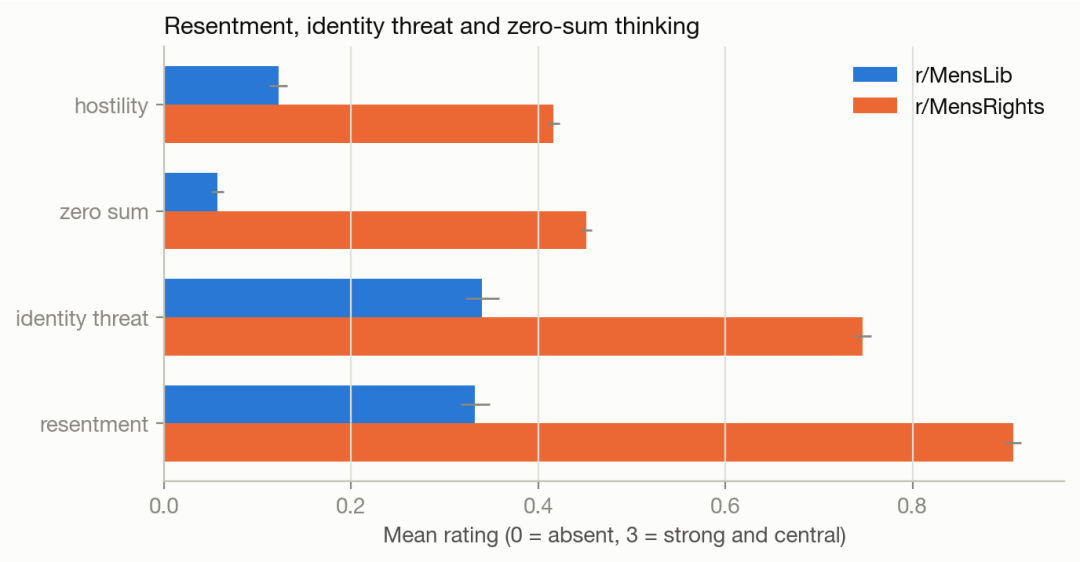


Figure 2: Mean construct ratings; bars show bootstrap standard errors

The constructs belong to the position, not the community

Splitting by coded stance rather than by subreddit changes the picture, and this is the more interesting result.

Table 2: Construct means by coded stance, pooling both subreddits

Stance	n	Resentment	Identity threat	Zero-sum	Hostility
Critical	5,284	1.830	1.610	0.982	0.698
Mixed	242	0.946	1.054	0.306	0.095
Supportive	1,026	0.432	0.440	0.066	0.317
Not about the ad	9,172	0.344	0.216	0.135	0.231

Comments critical of the advertisement average 1.83 on resentment and 1.61 on identity threat wherever they were posted; supportive comments average 0.43 and 0.44. Resentment and identity threat are therefore not simply what r/MensRights is like — they are what opposition to this advertisement consisted of, in both communities.

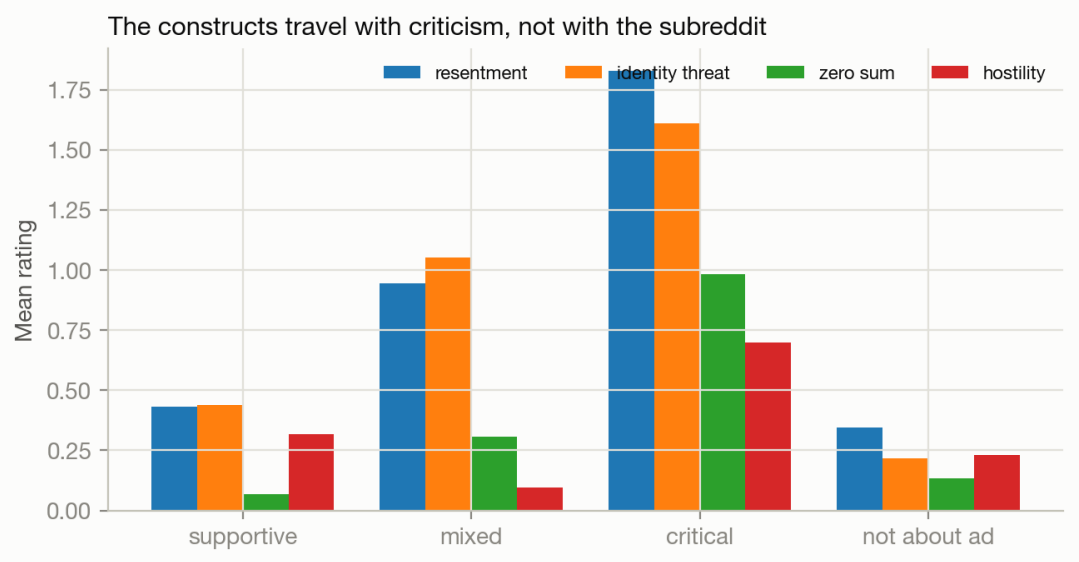


Figure 3: Constructs by coded stance

3 Tone tells a different and weaker story

Measured on tone alone, the two communities look alike: **both are strongly negative**, with mean polarity -0.335 in r/MensLib and -0.379 in r/MensRights, and 53.8 % against 59.2 % of comments read as negative. A reader expecting r/MensLib to have sounded positive about the advertisement will not find that here.

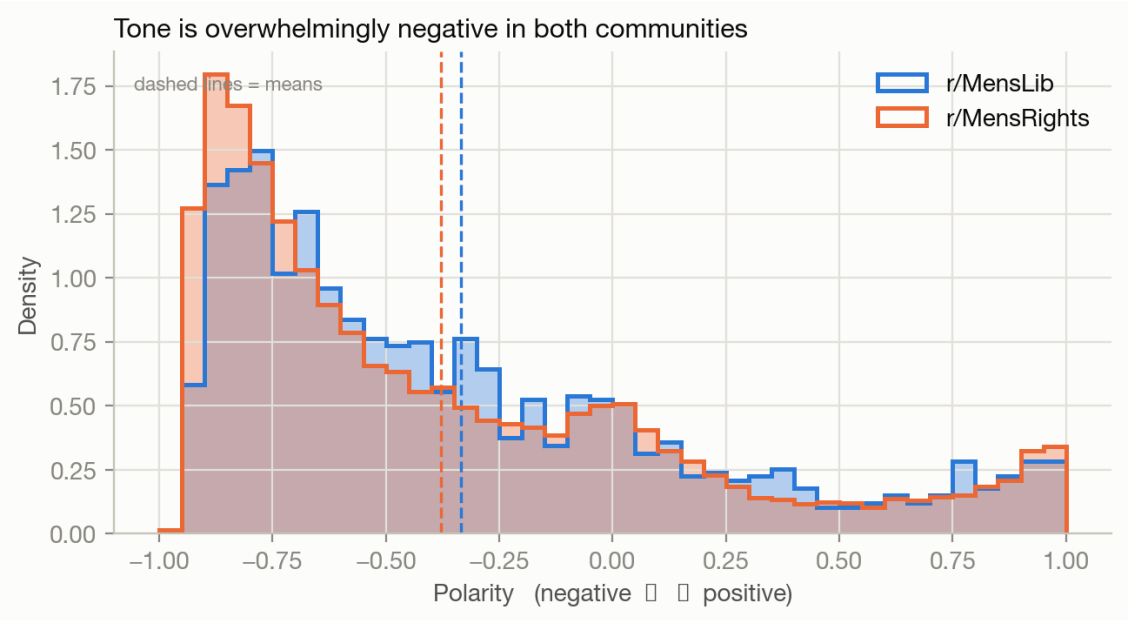


Figure 4: Polarity distributions; dashed lines are means

The distributions are bimodal in both communities, piling up at the negative end with a smaller positive cluster and little in between. The difference between them is a modest shift in those masses rather than a different shape.

Comment length hides most of the gap

The raw tone difference is $+0.044$; adjusted for length it is $+0.123$. The reason is mechanical: longer comments score more negative, falling from -0.04 in the shortest decile to about -0.50 in

the longest, and r/MensLib comments are twice as long (median 50 words against 25). Within every one of the ten length bands, r/MensLib is the less negative of the two.

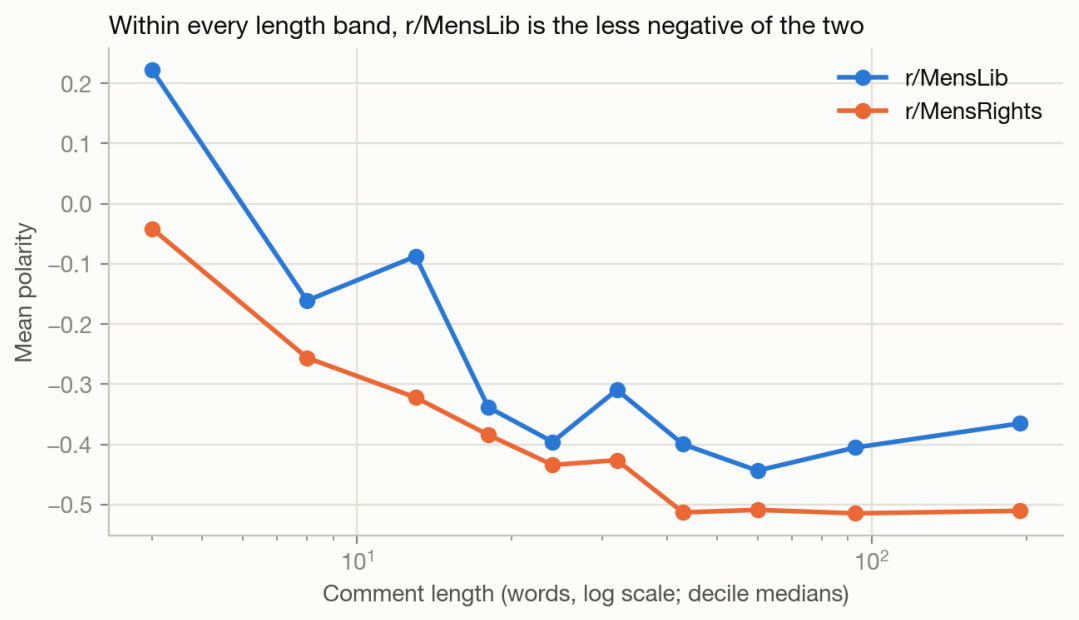


Figure 5: Mean polarity by comment-length decile

In a bivariate regression the tone difference is statistically indistinguishable from zero ($p = 0.165$); once log(words) enters, it is highly significant ($p = 1.3 \times 10^{-5}$). Any tone comparison between communities with different writing norms needs this control, or it will understate the difference.

4 Why the tone result cannot carry weight, and the stance result can

r/MensLib removed 22.4 % of its comments in these threads against r/MensRights' 4.9 %, and the removed text is unrecoverable. This is selective attrition directly on the outcome, and it is the reason the two results differ in standing.

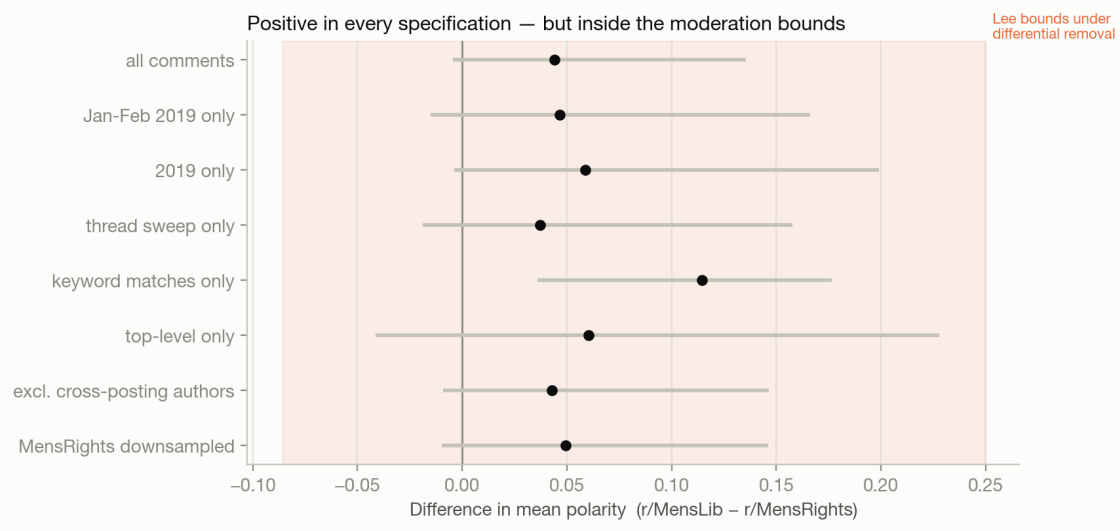


Figure 6: Tone gap across specifications; the shaded band is the Lee bounds under differential removal

For tone, bounds that account for the missing comments run from -0.086 to $+0.249$ and therefore contain zero: the sign of the tone difference is **not identified**. Since moderation removes hostile content, the naive estimate most likely flatters r/MensLib. For stance, the equivalent worst-case bounds run from -0.497 to -0.770 and exclude zero, so the direction holds even under the most

adverse assumption. The stance comparison is the one that supports an inference.

5 Emotional register and subject matter

The emotional registers are near-identical. Anger sits at 0.155 in r/MensLib against 0.167 in r/MensRights, and disgust at 0.204 against 0.203. The one real gap is **fear**, nearly twice as present in r/MensLib (0.092 against 0.052), consistent with its comments discussing vulnerability and what men are afraid to show; r/MensRights registers more surprise (0.084 against 0.060), the register of outrage and mockery.

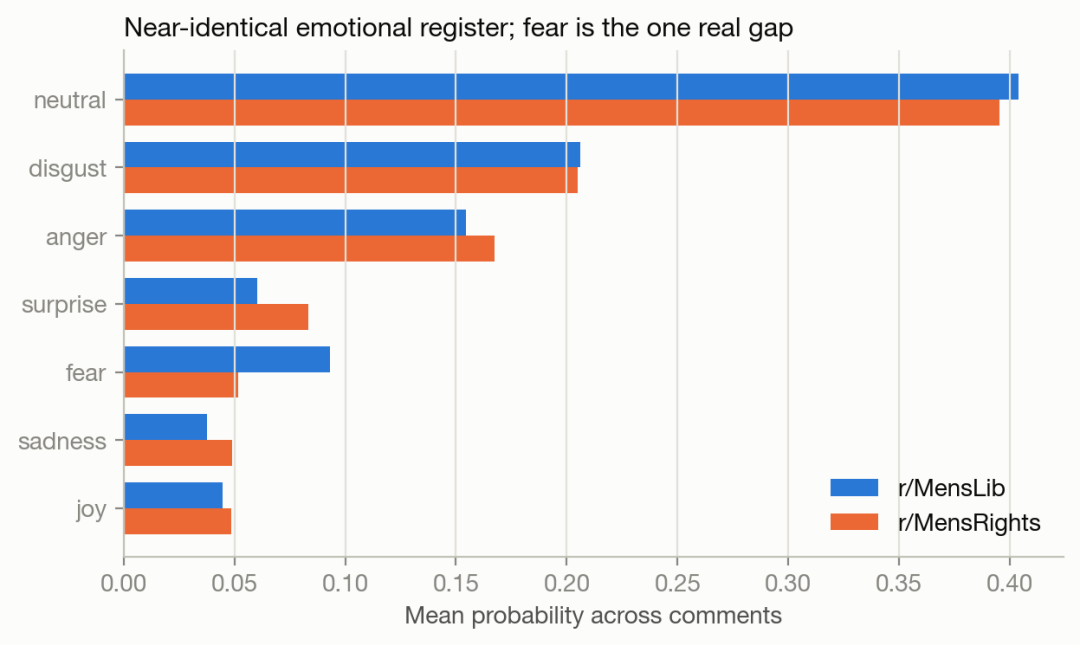


Figure 7: Mean emotion probability per comment

What separates the communities is subject matter. Clustering comments by meaning gives eight rough groupings, and the division of attention is clear: r/MensLib argued *inward* — personal testimony, and whether "toxic masculinity" is a useful term at all — while r/MensRights argued *outward*, at feminism, at the brand, and at what to buy instead.

Table 3: Theme prevalence, as a share of each community's comments

Theme	r/MensLib	r/MensRights	Skew
Direct exchanges and personal experience	33.2 %	13.8 %	2.4× r/MensLib
The term "toxic masculinity"	11.7 %	5.0 %	2.4× r/MensLib
Judging the advertisement itself	16.3 %	9.8 %	1.7× r/MensLib
Feminism, patriarchy and gender politics	14.2 %	21.8 %	1.5× r/MensRights
Gillette the brand and the backlash	6.5 %	12.7 %	2.0× r/MensRights
Razors, shaving and products	3.0 %	8.9 %	3.0× r/MensRights
Corporate ethics, boycotts, other brands	5.3 %	9.4 %	1.8× r/MensRights
Off-topic replies and one-liners	9.7 %	18.6 %	1.9× r/MensRights

These clusters are soft groupings rather than recovered structure, and the labels are interpretive; they should be read as a description of where attention went, not as a measurement.

6 What these results do not establish

1. **Stated position, not private belief.** The coding records the position a comment takes, which need not be what its author holds.

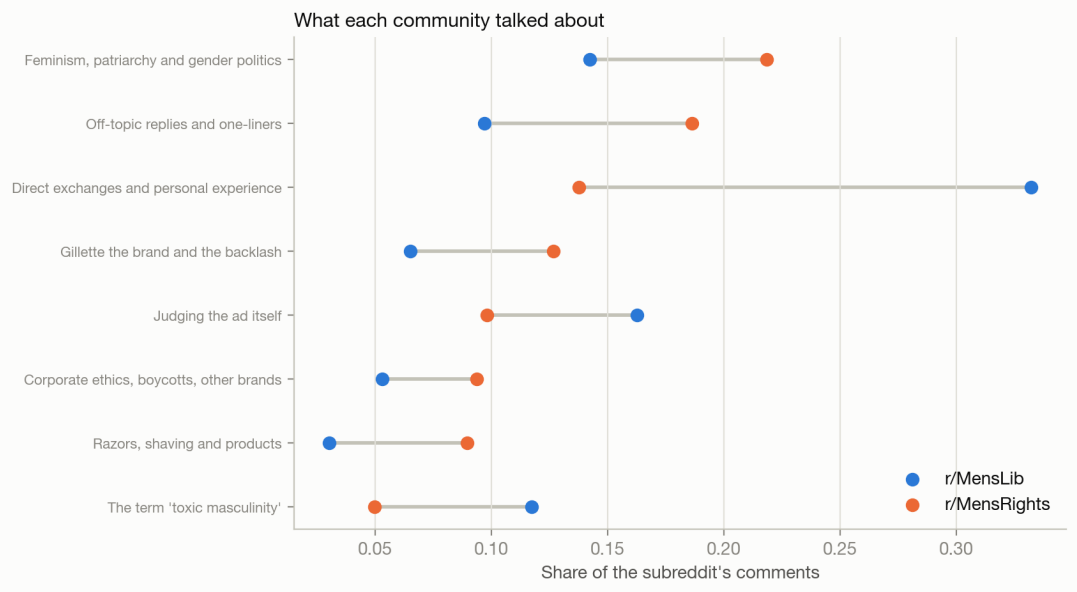


Figure 8: Theme prevalence by community

2. **A narrow base on one side.** r/MensLib contributes 510 positioned comments across 58 threads, five of which hold 81 % of them. Its 71.8 % supportive share rests on a small number of conversations.
3. **Conservative treatment of ambivalence.** "Mixed" is coded strictly, which may understate genuine ambivalence in a forum like r/MensLib that rewards it.
4. **Unequal populations.** 4,846 r/MensRights authors against 549 in r/MensLib, with time spans that diverge after 2019: r/MensLib effectively stopped discussing the advertisement after that year, while r/MensRights continued to invoke it through 2026.